
3. Sustainability as a megatrend in business

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INTRODUCTION

The topic of sustainability in business has existed for a long time. People have become more and more aware of how consumption impacts on our ecosystem and our planet overall. At the same time, business has had to take action and react to this situation. Since the late nineteenth and early twentieth century, as a reaction to industrialization, some small steps have been taken by business to, for example, control pollution and create green businesses (companies that protect the natural environment in which they operate by implementing sustainable practices such as environmentally-friendly operating procedures, product and material sourcing, and shipping methods); however, a stronger social movement emerged only in the 1960s (Bergquist, 2017). Currently there are many initiatives that are being undertaken by industries to deliver their goods and services in a sustainable manner, like reduction of waste in the supply chain or implementation of sustainability in the company culture, and this trend will not abate anytime soon. According to a 2019 study, ‘73 percent of global consumers are willing to change their consumption habits to lessen their negative impact on the environment, and sustainable product sales have grown by nearly 20 percent since 2014’ (Chladek, 2019). At the same time, surveys indicate that 90 per cent of CEOs say that sustainability is important to their companies’ success (Hoffman, 2018).

Business is also considered a key partner to address and help achieve the Sustainable Development Goals launched by the United Nations (2015), through contributions ranging from providing finances to delivering products and services that address sustainability (Kerrigan and Kulasoorya, 2020). The United Nations Sustainable Development Agenda states clearly that not only individuals but also companies should be strongly involved in achieving these goals by 2030 (Verma, 2017). Further reading on the United Nations Sustainable Development Agenda and the Sustainable Development Goals can be found in Chapter 1.

Much has been done in this regard, but much more is needed. Despite the many actions taken, environmental degradation has advanced, leading to the triple crisis of climate change, biodiversity loss and environmental pollution, which makes sustainability in business an imperative (Kerrigan and Kulasoorya, 2020).

DEFINITION OF MEGATREND, SUSTAINABILITY AND ESG

The term ‘*megatrend*’ was coined by John Naisbitt (1982, p. xxii) to describe the significant social, economic, political and/or technological movements and developments that shape our lives. In contrast to normal trends, their effects are stronger, their duration longer, and their scale larger (Mittelstaedt et al., 2014, p. 254).

Sustainability in broader terms is usually defined as ‘development that meets the needs of the present without compromising the ability of future generations to meet their own needs’, as described by the 1987 Brundtland Commission Report (United Nations, 1987). We can identify three main pillars of corporate sustainability, that is, economic, environmental and social, informally referred to as profits, planet and people (Beattie, 2021).

The term ‘*corporate sustainability*’, often used as a synonym for corporate social responsibility, describes a corporate management model that is an alternative to the traditional growth and profit-maximization model (Wilson, 2003). It can also fall under the broader term ‘environmental social governance’ (ESG), which is a set of standards for a company’s operations that socially conscious investors use to screen potential investments (Beattie, 2021). An important aspect of corporate sustainability is therefore pursuing societal goals, especially those related to sustainable development – *environmental protection* focused on reducing companies’ impact and their carbon footprint, *social justice and equity* understood as listening to and taking into account the interest and needs of people inside and outside the organization, and *economic development* referring to good corporate governance in order to ensure that a company is profitable (Wilson, 2003). The focus on ESG has been rapidly growing as many investors, regulators and other society stakeholders are requiring organizations to commit strongly to ESG standards and increase transparency of ESG and sustainability performance and reporting in order to better evaluate their long-term value. Organizations, on the other hand, acknowledge that taking into account the longer term, considering stakeholder needs and perceptions, and recognizing the social and environmental impact of their operations can have a positive impact on both their business and the planet. The detailed data that are reported for ESG assessment include among others (Hill, 2020; Berenberg, 2018; PwC, 2023):

1. Environment-related information: energy usage and efficiency, climate change strategy, greenhouse gas emissions, carbon footprint reduction, biodiversity loss, deforestation/reforestation, pollution levels and mitigation, hazardous materials and their disposal, water management.
2. Social-related information: employee safety and health, working conditions, fair pay and living wages; diversity, equity and inclusion; equal employment opportunity, employee and community engagement and benefits (e.g. training and development), responsible supply chain partnerships, human rights and privacy issues, animal testing, adhering to labour laws.
3. Governance-related information: corporate governance (e.g. preventing bribery and corruption, diversity of high management staff, cybersecurity and privacy practices), risk management, compliance, ethical business practices, avoiding conflicts of interests, accounting integrity and transparency, stakeholder rights.

The integration of ESG into the playbooks of institutional investors marked a crucial point after which ESG became widely adopted and recognized. ESG rating agencies started to emerge, assigning ESG scores to organizations. Moreover, new reporting frameworks were developed, contributing to the transparency and consistency of ESG information that firms are publicly disclosing. Even though ESG is competing for our attention with events such as the war in Ukraine, inflation and the rise in populism in some parts of the world, investing in a truly sustainable manner will still be essential in the years to come to facilitate the shift towards an eco-friendlier and more sustainable future.

HISTORICAL BACKGROUND

Business sustainability has a long history. It all started in the late nineteenth and early twentieth centuries as a first reaction towards the *industrial revolution*. Companies have, for centuries, taken advantage of natural resources to have enough energy and raw materials for their production (Bergquist, 2017). Coal was burned freely with no filters, which resulted in many industrial cities in America and Europe having enormous problems with air and water pollution. The Great Smog hit London in 1952 and in the United States similar events occurred connected with air and water pollution. Citizens started to notice the smog problem and this required introducing new environmental protection laws (Fedeli, 2019). In the 1960s, low production costs made the situation even worse, when much of the production was moved to countries with little environmental regulation. It became clear that governmental regulations on their own were not sufficient, and that business had to also take responsibility for the planet (Fedeli, 2019). In 1960, a much broader and stronger social movement appeared, including a mobilization of the masses, and new institutions to protect the environment were developed. In 1967, the Organisation for Economic Co-operation and Development (OECD) established advisory groups for different environmental problems, which were then extended each year afterwards. Between the 1960s and 1970s, the connection between business and the environment became even stronger and more complex. Technological innovations drove global commerce, but as a consequence the degradation of the environment advanced dramatically to a level that the world had not experienced before. An important event was the publication of the Brundtland Report in 1987, which introduced environmental issues into the concept of sustainable development. For businesses, it meant that they could no longer treat the environment as a limitless source of resources. Environmental catastrophes caused by corporations in the 1970s and 1980s (e.g. the Bhopal gas tragedy, which was a chemical accident at a pesticide plant in India; the Exxon Valdez oil spill) also drew more attention to business and put more pressure on corporations to act more sustainably (Porritt, 2012). Furthermore, in the 2000s, ‘green’ labelling was introduced into the concept of sustainability and sustainability entered the corporate language of the developed world for good. It is also worth mentioning that together with the growth of manufacturing, since the late-nineteenth century alternative green businesses involved in healthy food and in wind and solar energy started to emerge. However, it was only in the 1960s that this started to become a larger, even global trend. Sustainability started to become associated with something that can bring profits and improve the competitiveness even of large multinational corporations (Bergquist, 2017). Since then, we have witnessed the mainstreaming of sustainability in business. This was possible due to several factors, starting with the publishing of the Brundtland Report (Burton, 1987) as described above. Then there was the increased clarity of the concept of sustainability, which was also easier to adapt through the scope of the arguments, definitions, certifications and metrics. Furthermore, there was the changing of consumer preferences towards greener products. Other factors included that business risks were linked to climate change, and that there was a shift in government policies whereby financial barriers were removed when investing in sustainability. Last but not least, there was the increasing role and importance of non-governmental organizations (NGOs) (Bergquist, 2017).

It is also worth mentioning that from the 1990s a megatrend of business self-regulation, sometimes called voluntary regulation, emerged as a response to different stakeholders expect-

ing business, especially global companies, to take responsibility for the environmental issues due to their enormous influence and power (Bergquist, 2017).

New Area of Sustainability in Business

As mentioned above, sustainability in business is a growing trend. The market is a powerful institution and the businesses which operate within it are the most powerful entities as they do not have national boundaries and have plenty of resources. The progress towards a more sustainable future, including sustainable business activities, is clearly visible; however, it is still insufficient when we look at climate change, water scarcity, biodiversity loss and many other pressing issues (Hoffman, 2018). Therefore, we are now approaching a new phase of sustainability in business. Companies have been aware of the enormous challenge the world is facing and are now pushing for new market models. What is more, responsible businesses have already started to move ahead of politicians to take a broader role in ‘serving society’. The new way of doing business, called ‘market transformation’, is about looking at causes and not symptoms, developing tomorrow’s measures instead of current measures, creating sustainability (instead of limiting unsustainability only), and focusing on the market and society in which the companies operate (versus focusing on the organization itself). Thus, instead of following the rules of the market, business is trying to change them (Hoffman, 2018).

META- AND MEGATRENDS: GROWING BUSINESS CASE FOR SUSTAINABILITY IN THE FUTURE

Megatrends are influenced by metatrends, the latter spanning geography and time and being drivers for changes. Metatrends create changes that are the basis of megatrends. According to Melnyk et al. (2021), identified metatrends include:

- augmented human longevity,
- surging smart economy and increased connectivity,
- artificial intelligence (AI)–human collaboration,
- urbanized cellular agriculture,
- high-bandwidth brain–computer interface,
- instant economy of things,
- autonomous vehicles, and
- extended reality revolutionizing retail.

These metatrends, with an increase in global environmental awareness and growing concerns over climate change, will likely keep driving enterprises to invest in sustainability, either due to necessity or due to reputation concerns and for marketing purposes. The growing global middle class has high sustainability expectations and the money to contribute to philanthropic spending. Customers increasingly demand that companies act in a socially responsible manner and are often willing to pay more for their products (Mohr et al., 2001). One key outcome of these metatrends is that the business case for sustainability is becoming more salient, and hence it is likely to remain a megatrend going forward. This is not only due to societal pull, but also due to technological push. Breakthroughs in materials science, further enabled by AI,

will allow companies to achieve significant reductions in waste and pollution. One company's waste will become another company's revenue stream and profit opportunity.

A second group of metatrends is anchored in social science and humanities, and these include the 'new normal', increasingly frequent discontinuities and tensions, human behaviour and emotions of consumers as key features of products and services (for example, through personalized and targeted communication enabled by big data and AI), hyper-connectivity and isolation, abundance of information and growing inequalities (Göpel, 2016). Therefore, another outcome of these trends points to a need for a broader and more detailed definition of sustainability and sustainable business practice in the face of growing complexity and connectivity, one that addresses current and future challenges. We will elaborate more on this towards the end of this chapter.

Finally, it's impossible to think about the future and not consider Covid-19 implications, and how much the pandemic is a game changer, or how much it is simply putting the problems we have been already struggling with under a magnifying glass. The pandemic, at least for most of us, has dramatically changed our lives at an unprecedented speed. This has further challenged the fundamentals of how companies do business and could subsequently lead to a re-evaluation of long-held assumptions about the global economy. Pre-existent threats to business and society have been amplified and now it is even more clear that the long-term strategic thinking set out by the Sustainable Development Goals is necessary. Moreover, the pandemic has highlighted the interdependent scope and the interconnected nature of our systems, giving rise to more complex vulnerabilities and cascading effects. These problems are hardly new. They are simply more exposed now and we stand before a new opportunity, namely to 'build forward better' to ensure the post-pandemic world is fundamentally improved. Future resilience is rooted in sustainability.

Sustainable business still needs to be an economically viable business. The links between sustainability and economic performance have been widely debated. In the beginning the conversation focused on whether these links exist. It has since shifted to discussing what kind of links we can identify (Schaltegger and Wagner, 2017). As the Prime Minister of the Netherlands, Mark Rutte, put it: 'Sustainability is a clear business case. It promotes growth and is essential to long-term business success.' Below we discuss connections that are made particularly salient in the face of the metatrends presented above. These are considered megatrends.

New Business Models, Creating Shared Value and Stakeholder Engagement

Corporate sustainability looks at the whole value chain, that is, everyone from end-consumers to shareholders. Traditional business models are frequently anchored in a zero-sum game logic and look to create value for shareholders, often at the expense of other stakeholders. Therefore, sustainable businesses require new models that create value for all stakeholders: employees, shareholders, supply chains partners, society and the environment. Having introduced the concept 'creating shared value', Porter and Kramer (2019) connect societal and economic progress and argue that 'societal needs, not just conventional economic needs, define markets, and social harms can create internal costs for firms'. There are three central ways that companies can create shared value opportunities: reconceiving products and markets, redefining productivity in the value chain, and enabling local cluster development. Shared value blurs the line between for-profit and non-profit organizations and indeed new kinds of hybrid enterprises

have been rapidly appearing (Porter and Kramer, 2011). Connecting social and economic spheres requires constant engagement with and learning from key stakeholders and this is where a significant portion of the strategic value of this approach comes from. Technological advances, disruptive changes and economic shifts are rapidly rendering traditional business models obsolete. The increasing popularity of co-creation has also led to incorporating this approach in business modelling itself. Strategy formulation in the co-creation paradigm begins with a focus on the entire ecosystem, and imagines and drafts a new value chain that benefits all participants, agents and stakeholders and defines efficiency in terms of maximizing the size of the pie as opposed to maximizing a single firm's or agent's slice of the pie (Ramaswamy and Gouillart, 2010). Therefore, business models with co-innovation value are rooted in mutual benefit and are by nature aligned with sustainability and stakeholder engagement. Moreover, this approach minimizes risk and increases preparedness in the face of an ever-changing business landscape, as regular dialogue better positions the company to anticipate and react to economic, social, environmental and regulatory changes as they arise (Whelan and Fink, 2016).

Better Risk Management

Many business models for innovative technologies do not achieve market success because they do not address the problem of misaligned incentives and because their structure does not properly distribute risks during implementation, and therefore does not lower them (Blasberg, 2021). Supply chains are becoming longer, more complex and hence more vulnerable to adverse incidents, such as natural disasters and civil unrest. This risk is even higher due to climate change, clean resource scarcity and poor labour conditions (Whelan and Fink, 2016). In a McKinsey sustainability-assessment survey with 340 respondents, over 90 per cent of them pointed to a specific event or risk (e.g. pressure from consumers or growing commodity prices) that directly triggered their commitment to sustainability. Over 50 per cent of respondents mentioned long-term risks to their businesses, such as reputation concerns, regulatory problems and operational risks. The value at stake from risk-related sustainability issues can be as high as 70 per cent of earnings before interest, taxes, depreciation and amortization (Berg et al., 2015). A large study on climate change data and 7,800 supplier companies selling to 75 multinationals found that 72 per cent of the companies reported that climate change presents risks that could significantly impact their operations, revenue or expenditures (CDP, 2016). Contrary to traditional forms of business risk, social and environmental risks surface over a longer time period and impact businesses across many dimensions. Importantly, they fall predominantly outside the enterprise's control. Climate change is reaching a point where businesses are internalizing the external costs they have been frequently ignoring (i.e. by understanding the long-term implications to their operations but also taking a broader supply chain perspective). These multidimensional risks require adaptive strategies and co-innovation. In co-created sustainable business modelling, stakeholders will ideate together outside their traditional boundaries and experiment with value propositions.

Co-innovation

Not only are co-creation and stakeholder engagement very much aligned with a sustainable mindset, but moreover sustainable strategic direction and investment can go beyond risk man-

agement and be a driver of innovation itself. This can occur through a range of channels; for example, clusters and capable local suppliers can increase flexibility, foster faster learning and enable innovation (Porter and Kramer, 2011). Recognizing social and environmental needs can lead to novel product and process development.

Higher Financial Performance

This key trend captures the changing perceptions of trade-offs between profits and sustainability. The financial benefits of a sustainable strategy build on previously mentioned elements such as better risk management and adverse incident preparedness, higher innovation potential and increased competitive advantage, and finally cost saving through a more resource-neutral production process. Christmann (2000), based on survey data from 88 chemical companies, found tangible positive effects of ‘best practices’ of environmental management on firm performance. These ‘best practices’ enable firms to simultaneously protect the environment and reduce cost. The correlations are becoming more visible as investors can now track the high performers on ESG (environmental, social and governance) factors and analyse financial performance against ESG performance. This is yet another trend that contributes to sustainability as a megatrend in business.

Attractiveness as an Employer

Ehnert (2009) proposes that sustainability can be used as a ‘deliberate strategy’ for human resource management. Corporate sustainability initiatives can increase employee loyalty, efficiency and productivity and improve recruitment, retention and morale. Research is finding that twenty-first-century employees are focusing more on mission, purpose and work–life balance. Building on the importance of stakeholder engagement, companies who follow this sustainable approach tend to treat their employees precisely as critical stakeholders, which in turn is valued by the workers and contributes to other sustainability benefits, such as innovative potential.

Growing Consumer Demand and Awareness, Building Consumer Loyalty

The market for sustainable goods is growing. Companies used to be, and some still are, sceptical about consumer interest in sustainable products, specifically when it comes to their actual willingness to pay for a greener product or service. However, the majority (73 per cent) of global consumers say they would definitely or probably change their consumption habits to reduce their impact on the environment (Nielsen, 2019). This willingness to pay for sustainability is particularly on the rise among millennials and younger generations. The growing share of sustainability-minded customers is another trend that supports and favours sustainability as a megatrend in business, as environmental awareness can be then converted into increased sales.

Some of the scepticism about consumers’ sustainability commitment is a result of firms’ past mistakes, lack of transparency and opportunistic behaviour. Early on, companies tended to price ‘sustainable’ products at a high mark-up, which did not necessarily reflect high quality or a positive impact across the environmental, social and economic pillars. However, after lessons learned, consumer expectations have shifted. Today’s consumers expect more trans-

parency and honesty as well as a more tangible impact. Given increased competition across sustainability dimensions, consumers can now choose from a range of products that meet these criteria.

Authenticity and Greenwashing: The Rise of the Sustainability Reporting Megatrend

If sustainability as a megatrend is significantly driven by consumer demand, then there is a question of authenticity and credibility of reporting. A number of consumers, activists and academics believe that a significant share of companies are profiting from insincere claims of sustainability (Mattis, 2015). According to the Cambridge Dictionary, greenwashing is a 'behaviour or activities that make people believe that a company is doing more to protect the environment than it really is'. CSR-washing, where CSR stands for corporate social responsibility, is argued to be the new greenwashing (Mattis, 2015), and consumers often see it this way as well. International surveys indeed show that the majority of consumers believe that the key reason behind corporate sustainable initiatives is marketing (Globescan, 2010; Kanter, 2009), so a profit-oriented rather than planet-oriented motivation. Nearly two-thirds of Americans polled believe that companies overstate their commitment with respect to the natural environment (Katz, 2008). The debate on the authenticity and perception of corporate sustainability claims continues, and Pope and Wæraas (2016) argue that whether CSR-washing is common or rare becomes also a matter of perception rather than of fact.

Nonetheless, consumers' expectations regarding transparency and impact bring us to the importance of comparable and reliable reporting. Interestingly, while the strength of the sustainability megatrend in business can be debated, sustainability reporting has definitely been a salient trend in the recent past. Reporting has received, and will continue to receive, increased attention from consumers and competitors, investors and regulators. This has resulted in a proliferation of sustainability disclosure regimes and standards (Chelli et al., 2018). The range of approaches to disclosure, however, limits the comparability and reliability of the information disclosed (Fisch, 2018).

In response to growing concerns about standardization and comparability, the World Economic Forum International Business Council (IBC) issued the 'Compact for Responsive and Responsible Leadership', which has been signed by more than 140 CEOs. It states that 'society is best served by corporations that have aligned their goals to the long-term goals of society', which it sets out to be UN Sustainable Development Goals. Accordingly, the metrics are grounded in the goals and organized into four pillars: Principles of Governance, Planet, People and Prosperity (for an overview see Table 3.1). Performance across these pillars is of course interdependent. Prioritization of themes and metrics follows five key criteria: 1) Consistency with existing frameworks and standards, 2) Materiality to long-term value creation, 3) Extent of actionability, 4) Universality across industries and business models and 5) Monitoring feasibility of reporting.

The reason behind this initiative is to enable firms to begin reporting in a consistent fashion on key dimensions of sustainable and shared value creation, which in turn will catalyse faster progress towards the creation of a more formal, systemic and generally accepted solution. As for reporting as a megatrend, what will be key is what the final consensus will be regarding the specific dimensions of sustainability and metrics. What we will measure will be what we monitor and track, and ultimately what businesses maximize or minimize. Therefore, these chosen indicators will inform future corporate sustainability trajectories and actions.

Table 3.1 The four pillars of sustainability metrics

Principles of Governance	Planet	People	Prosperity
The definition of governance is evolving as organizations are increasingly expected to define and embed their purpose at the centre of their business. But the principles of agency, accountability and stewardship continue to be vital for truly ‘good governance’	An ambition to protect the planet from degradation, including through sustainable consumption and production, sustainably managing its natural resources and taking urgent action on climate change so that it can support the needs of the present and future generations	An ambition to end poverty and hunger, in all their forms and dimensions, and to ensure that all human beings can fulfil their potential with dignity in the spirit of equality and in a healthy environment	An ambition to ensure that all human beings can enjoy prosperous and fulfilling lives and that economic, social and technological progress occurs in harmony with nature

Source: World Economic Forum with Deloitte, EY, KPMG and PWC (2020). Definitions for Planet, People and Prosperity taken from the UN’s 2030 Agenda for Sustainable Development of Governance.

This is not the first initiative of this kind. Koh and Leong (2017) chart the rise of sustainability reporting as a megatrend. This has attracted significant regulatory attention and led to the development of rules and regulations governing sustainability. Currently, the law on sustainability is still not perfectly clear, including the scope of sustainability reporting, targets and aspirations, as well as board responsibility. As corporations meet consumer and stakeholder expectations via growing sustainability information, they also expose themselves to higher liability risk. Nonetheless, consumers and regulators, as well as other stakeholders, will likely become more active in demanding and evaluating information and metrics on corporate sustainability. Sustainability as a megatrend will be reflected in the growing commitment to better reporting.

Further discussion on business drivers, barriers and opportunities for mainstreaming LCSA can be found in Chapter 28.

CONCLUSIONS

Enterprises are facing growing expectations from their consumers and other stakeholders to define their purpose beyond profit maximization and to pursue these objectives in a way that integrates the various aspects of sustainability with the core of their business. This integration should mirror the way environmental, social and economic pillars of sustainability are interlinked. Companies have all kinds of motivations for making sustainable investments, ranging from cost reduction and improving operational efficiency, to marketing and media boost, and possibly many in between. For sustainability as a megatrend in business to grow going forward, it needs an expanding business case and favourable drivers of change and metatrends. Megatrends such as new business models, better risk management, co-innovation, higher financial performance, attractiveness as an employer, growing consumer demand and awareness, and the rise of sustainability reporting need to be considered when designing sustainability strategies. The urgent macro need for sustainable development in response to demographic change, resource scarcity and climate change, paired with micro-level incentives for enterprises to pursue a sustainable strategy (from creating shared value to better risk management and consumer loyalty), point to sustainability continuing to be a megatrend well into

the future. However, going forward we will likely need to have a wider debate and dialogue about the definition and the shape of sustainability that our futures will require.

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